VOL. I WEEKDAY EDITION

THE SPACEX DISPATCH

Weekday briefing on SpaceX launches, Starlink, AI and the SPCX stock

WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 21, 2026 MARKET DATA AS OF TUE OCT 20 CLOSE

THE MORNING PICTURE

Revenue up 161% as AI becomes the biggest business

SpaceX reported third-quarter revenue of $14.58 billion, against the $12.72 billion analysts expected, and net income of $4.4 billion, compared with a $1.1 billion loss a year earlier, Reuters reported. The Super Intelligence (SI) segment brought in $7.6 billion, more than Starlink and launch combined, according to the company's results release.

"We are in an inflection moment for SpaceX across launch, connectivity and superintelligence," Musk said on the call. SPCX, which closed down 0.11% at $147.79 on Tuesday, rose 4.6% after hours, Bloomberg Law reported. That evening, a Starlink launch from California was scrubbed for a technical issue.

THURSDAY · LOCK-UP RELEASE

Up to 1.3 billion more shares can trade

Thu Oct 22 · second full trading day after the results

Under the prospectus, up to 1.3 billion locked-up Class A shares, 28% of those under the 180-day lock-up, become sellable on Thursday, followed by up to 328.4 million (7%) on Saturday, October 24, and the rest on December 8. Musk's shares stay locked until the 366th day after the offering.

I · THIRD-QUARTER RESULTS

A profit, and a Starship catch attempt next month

Capital spending nearly tripled to $19.6 billion, most of it for AI compute.

The numbers

Operating income was $2.79 billion and adjusted EBITDA (earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortization) $8.81 billion; diluted GAAP earnings were 35 cents a share, according to the release. On the IBES basis SpaceX earned 45 cents, against a 13-cent average estimate, Reuters reported. SI revenue rose 830% from a year earlier, driven by new cloud-services agreements, the Cursor acquisition, which contributed $608 million, and Grok adoption; SI operating income was $431 million after $1.2 billion of Cursor-related share-based compensation.

SpaceX makes its AI money mainly by renting data-center capacity to developers including Anthropic, Google and Reflection AI, and AI took $16.4 billion of the quarter's $19.6 billion in capital spending, a level the company expects to hold near term, Reuters noted. Nameplate compute reached 1.7 gigawatts (GW) on September 30. Cash and equivalents were $51.3 billion, plus $38.6 billion of marketable securities (release).



The launch tower's arms catch a Super Heavy booster at Starbase, Texas, during Starship's fifth flight test on Oct. 13, 2024. Flight 15 is meant to catch both the booster and the ship.

PHOTO: STEVE JURVETSON / WIKIMEDIA COMMONS · CC BY 2.0 (CROPPED)

Space: 35 launches

Space revenue was $1.8 billion, up 84% from the second quarter, on 12 customer and 23 internal launches, among them NASA's Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope, and Starship Flight 14 delivered 26 Starlink V3 satellites, about 10 times the downlink capacity a Falcon 9 Starlink launch adds. New orders include three NASA crew missions to the International Space Station, 18 National Security Space Launch missions, three commercial Starfall missions and a Starship payload to the lunar surface (release).

"For Flight 15, which we expect to happen next month, we're going to attempt to catch both the booster and the ship," Musk said on the call. "Success is not guaranteed on these first flights, but I'd say it's more likely than not that this succeeds next flight." He expects weekly Starship flights at some point in the first half of next year and twice-weekly or more by the end of next year, according to a Motley Fool transcript; Spaceflight Now posted the same targets at 4:42 p.m. EDT.

Guidance

Chief Financial Officer Bret Johnsen guided to fourth-quarter capital spending of $35 billion to $40 billion and first-quarter 2027 revenue of $33 billion to $37 billion, and said SpaceX remains on track for $100 billion in annual recurring revenue (ARR) by the end of this year. Backlog was $63 billion on September 30, about $42 billion of it expected to be recognized within a year. Nameplate compute should reach 2.5 to 3 gigawatts by year-end; "I would be surprised if we brought on less than 13 gigawatts of compute by the end of next year," Musk said, putting ARR at the end of 2027 at "somewhere between $500 billion and $1 trillion" (transcript).

QUICK HIT

Starbase, Louisiana. SpaceX announced plans for a second Starship spaceport in Louisiana, "designed to support thousands of Starship flights a year, with the first launch targeted for 2029," according to the release.

The merger question

Musk said Tesla and SpaceX have each formed special committees of independent directors to study a combination at shareholders' request. "I do think there's a lot of merit to combining the companies," he said, but "some people out there assume that a SpaceX and Tesla merger is a certainty. I think that would be overstating it," Bloomberg Law reported. Tesla shares rose 1.2% after hours.

II · UPCOMING FLIGHTS

Starlink 15-15 tries again tonight

Every SpaceX launch on the books for the next two months, with how firm each date is and where it comes from. Times are Eastern: EDT through November 1, EST after.

DATE / TIME (EDT/EST)	VEHICLE	MISSION	PAD	STATUS	SOURCES
Wed Oct 21, window opens 5:59 p.m. EDT	Falcon 9	Starlink 15-15, 27 V2 Mini satellites; booster B1063, 36th flight; drone ship Of Course I Still Love You	SLC-4E, Vandenberg	Tentative	Spaceflight Now; Launch Library 2 (7:02 p.m.)
Sat Oct 24, 1:29 a.m. EDT	Falcon 9	Starlink 15-16	SLC-4E, Vandenberg	Tentative	Launch Library 2
Wed Oct 28, 12:31 a.m. EDT	Falcon 9	Starlink 15-18	SLC-4E, Vandenberg	Tentative	Launch Library 2
Thu Nov 5, 5:34 p.m. EST	Falcon 9	NROL-195, National Reconnaissance Office	SLC-4E, Vandenberg	Tentative	Launch Library 2
NET Nov 8	Starship	Flight 15, Ship 42 and Booster 22; booster and ship catches planned	Pad 2, Starbase, Texas	Preliminary	NASASpaceflight (unofficial); SpaceX: "next month"
NET Nov 10	Falcon 9	Starlink 15-21	SLC-4E, Vandenberg	Preliminary	Launch Library 2
NET Nov 30	Falcon 9	Cygnus NG-25 cargo to the ISS	SLC-40, Cape Canaveral	Preliminary	Launch Library 2
December	Starship	Flight 16, likely Ship 43 and Booster 23	Possibly LC-39A, Kennedy	Preliminary	NASASpaceflight (unofficial)

Status: Confirmed means the operator or NASA has announced the date and time. Tentative means a specific date appears in published schedules but has not been confirmed by SpaceX or its customer. Preliminary means only a no-earlier-than (NET) date or month, or an unofficial target. Changes since Tuesday's issue: Starlink 15-15 slipped a day. Its launch time moved from 7:10 to 7:22 and then 8:06 p.m. EDT Tuesday before the attempt was called off ahead of fueling; "It appears teams ran into a technical issue," Spaceflight Now posted at 7:06 p.m. EDT. SpaceX has not described the problem. Pads: Space Launch Complex 4 East (SLC-4E), Space Launch Complex 40 (SLC-40), Launch Complex 39A (LC-39A).

Starship Flight 15



A Falcon 9 lifts off from Space Launch Complex 4E at Vandenberg Space Force Base with NASA's SWOT satellite on Dec. 16, 2022. Starlink 15-15 flies from the same pad.

PHOTO: NASA/KEEGAN BARBER · PUBLIC DOMAIN

Pad 2 at Starbase "is ready for Booster 22," after teams ran a full test of its water deluge system Tuesday evening, a post shared by NASASpaceflight showed, and a second test followed about 10 minutes later. Booster 22's move to the pad should be next, while Ship 43 now looks likely to go to the Massey's test site rather than the launch tower, NASASpaceflight wrote at 6:52 p.m. EDT.

Flight 15 is targeting November 8, according to NASASpaceflight, with Ship 42 and Booster 22; Flight 16, likely Booster 23 and Ship 43, is aimed at December and could be the first Starship launch from Launch Complex 39A in Florida. "We expect the license for our Flight 15 to include return to launch site and tower catch for both stages," Shotwell said on the call (transcript).

III · STARLINK

13.6 million subscribers and a path to "several hundred billion"

Subscriber counts beat one estimate and missed another, and revenue per user is below 2023 levels.

Starlink ended September with 13.6 million consumer subscribers, up from 12.0 million three months earlier. That topped the 12.19 million analysts expected, Reuters reported, but fell short of the 14.2 million Bloomberg analysts expected, Business Insider reported; the count excludes enterprise and aviation customers. Average monthly revenue per consumer subscriber was $69, down from $99 in 2023 as cheaper plans roll out abroad, though up 5% from the second quarter. Connectivity revenue rose 69% from a year earlier to $5.2 billion, with enterprise and government revenue up 91% (release).

About 3,800 aircraft had been fitted with Starlink by the end of September. "Aviation remains a major growth opportunity, as we're still early in the installation phase with many of the largest carriers worldwide," Chief Financial Officer Bret Johnsen said on the call, Business Insider reported.

Starlink Mobile

"The vast majority of mobile connectivity is actually WiFi," President Gwynne Shotwell said. "As far as the mix goes, I think we expect that the S-band spectrum will provide the majority. And then obviously, you need the low-band spectrum, the 800 megahertz spectrum, to basically penetrate buildings," Business Insider reported. The 800 MHz purchase, agreed October 8, is expected to close in the first half of 2027 (release).

"I can say we do see a clear path to several hundred billion dollars a year in connectivity revenue," Musk said, adding that the plan deserved "a forum that's not limited to a few minutes at an earnings call," The Verge reported. Starlink Mobile passed 22 million monthly users, up 37% from the second quarter; SpaceX plans to fly its second-generation Mobile satellites through next year and start U.S. service with the new spectrum in early 2028, Shotwell said. Users will need "a few hundred" V3 satellites in orbit to feel faster service, which she expects by the middle of next year (transcript).

IV · AI & COMPUTE

"We could rent out our compute several times over"

Musk said SpaceX is "hounded relentlessly by every hyperscaler" for capacity and prefers short contracts at spot prices.

Roughly half of SpaceX's compute is meant for its own use and half for rent, a split that could move "60-40 one way or the other," Musk said. "Our belief is that the value of compute per watt will increase over time, not decrease," he said, adding that short-term contracts are renewing "at higher dollars per watt, not lower." Johnsen said new deployments pay back in less than a year at current pricing, which is tracking slightly above the high end of the $30 to $50 per watt range discussed last quarter (transcript).

Paid weekly users of Grok Bot, the company's agent launched in August, reached 800,000 earlier this month, and Grok Enterprise customers with more than $1 million in run-rate revenue rose 50% from the second quarter, Shotwell said. SpaceX is casting turbine blades and vanes in its rocket-engine

foundry, which Musk said lets it bring power online "12 to 18 months faster than anyone else" (transcript).

QUICK HIT

Little League. Musk said SpaceX launches almost 90% of all mass to orbit, against about 6% for China, and has put the same team on building data centers: "This is a bit like the New York Yankees playing in Little League. It's not fair" (transcript).

V · FILINGS: SEC, FAA & FCC

The results 8-K

One new SEC filing; no new FAA Federal Register notices or FCC actions since Tuesday's issue.

SEC

8-K · Oct 20, 4:00 p.m. EDT — Results of operations (Item 2.02) and exhibits (Item 9.01): the third-quarter release, filed as Exhibit 99.1. Filing

> No other filings for Space Exploration Technologies Corp. (CIK 0001181412) were accepted on the SEC's Electronic Data Gathering, Analysis, and Retrieval system (EDGAR) between 8:00 a.m. EDT Tuesday and 8:55 a.m. EDT Wednesday. Latest insider filings:

Form 4/A · Sep 30 · Antonio Gracias, director — Amends his report of the September 11 in-kind distribution of 42,790,223 shares by Valor entities; 460,624,307 shares afterward. Filing

Form 4 · Sep 24 · Gwynne Shotwell, President and Chief Operating Officer — Exercised options for 342,170 shares on September 22 and sold the same number at weighted-average prices of $151.15 to $154.72; 2,472,035 shares afterward. Filing

FAA

Open · Starbase PEIS — Comments on the FAA's Programmatic Environmental Impact Statement for more Starship-Super Heavy operations at Starbase (docket FAA-2026-12808) are due November 30. Federal Register

FCC

800 MHz purchase — The deal for up to 14 MHz of paired 800 MHz spectrum is subject to regulatory approval (release).

Oct 29 · Open meeting — Votes on more spectrum for Supplemental Coverage from Space and a proposed 25 MHz auction. Broadband Breakfast

Nov 4 · Surety bond — Due under the October 6 order granting 15,000 Gen2 direct-to-device satellites in part. Exterra

Takeaways

1. Q3 revenue rose 161% to $14.58 billion; net income was $4.4 billion.
2. AI revenue of $7.6 billion is now SpaceX's largest business.
3. Starship Flight 15 is expected next month, with two catch attempts.
4. Starlink 15-15 was scrubbed for a technical issue; it tries again tonight.
5. Up to 1.3 billion locked-up shares can be sold from Thursday.

SOURCES

Posts by @SpaceflightNow and @NASASpaceflight on X; SpaceX results release (SEC Form 8-K); Spaceflight Now, Launch Library 2, NASASpaceflight, Federal Register; Reuters, Business Insider, Bloomberg Law, The Verge, The Motley Fool (call transcript), Broadband Breakfast, Exterra; SEC EDGAR; Yahoo Finance via yfinance; CBOE. Photos: NASA (public domain); Wikimedia Commons (Steve Jurvetson, CC BY 2.0).

The SpaceX Dispatch is an independent weekday digest of public news, X posts, regulatory filings and market data about Space Exploration Technologies Corp., and is not affiliated with the company. Quotes are verbatim; emoji in quoted posts are omitted for print. Market data are delayed and may be revised. Not investment advice.

Flat into the report, higher after it

SPCX slipped 0.11% in regular trading as the Nasdaq Composite ended fractionally lower, Investopedia reported, then rose 4.6% after the results, according to Bloomberg Law.

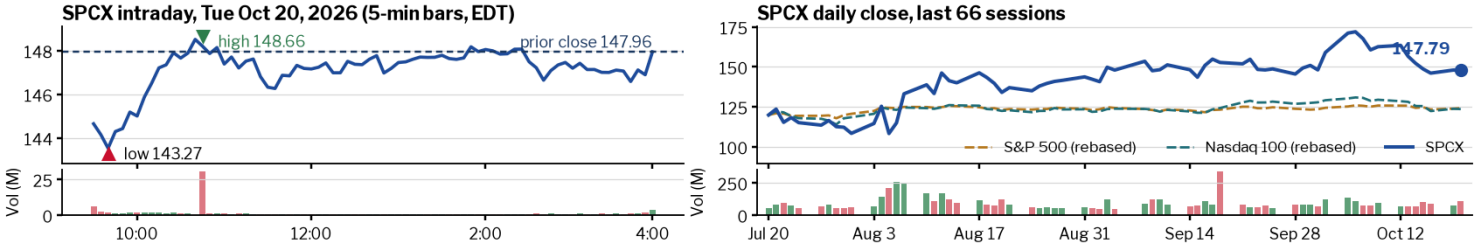
CLOSE	CHANGE	OPEN	DAY HIGH	DAY LOW
$147.79	−$0.17	$146.17	$148.66	$143.27
Tue Oct 20, 4:00 p.m. EDT	−0.11% vs $147.96	regular session	10:45 a.m. EDT bar	9:40 a.m. EDT bar

VOLUME	RANGE SINCE IPO	MARKET CAP	5-DAY / 1-MONTH	SINCE LISTING
108.30M	$105–$226	$1.95T	−5.59% / −2.67%	+9.5%
+16.5% vs 30-session avg 92.97M	no 52-week history (listed Jun 12)	13.18B Class A+B shares × close; $2.01T with Cursor shares	5 and 21 sessions	vs $135 IPO price; −8.18% vs first close

SINCE IPO, OCT 20

low $104.83 · Aug 3 — close $147.79 — high $225.64 · Jun 16

50-day avg $148.62



As of close Oct 20, 2026; times EDT. Source: Yahoo Finance via yfinance (regular session, unadjusted). Dashed navy = prior close; triangles = session high/low; volume green/red = up/down vs prior bar; index lines rebased to the first close shown.

RELATIVE PERFORMANCE, AS OF OCT 20 CLOSE

TICKER	1-DAY	5-DAY	1-MONTH	SINCE JUN 12
SPCX	**−0.11%**	**−5.59%**	**−2.67%**	**−8.18%**
S&P 500	+0.28%	−1.19%	−0.67%	+3.78%
Nasdaq 100	−0.13%	−3.53%	−3.25%	−0.49%
RKLB	−0.90%	−20.74%	−27.17%	−50.29%
ASTS	−1.77%	−12.61%	−33.54%	−50.09%
IRDM	−0.54%	−5.97%	−8.86%	−7.14%

OPTIONS (CBOE, WED OCT 21, 8:36 A.M. EDT)

EXPIRY	CALL OI	PUT OI	P/C	ATM IV	TOP CALL / PUT
Oct 21	95,615	103,234	1.08	169.0%	$160 / $120
Oct 23	188,613	183,729	0.97	111.3%	$170 / $140
Oct 26	16,013	10,627	0.66	83.2%	$155 / $140
All expiries	**2,248,761**	**2,391,990**	**1.06**		**30-day IV index 57.7**

ANALYST CONSENSUS · OCT 21

Strong buy	8
Buy	22
Hold	5
Sell	3
Strong sell	0
Mean (1 = strong buy)	1.79
Mean target (31 analysts)	$224.81 (+52.1%)
Median target	$225.00
High / low target	$450.00 / $118.00

SHORT INTEREST & OWNERSHIP

Short interest, Sep 30	181.00M
Change vs. prior report	+4.2%
Short % of float	2.71%
Days to cover	2.01
Held by insiders	12.73%
Held by institutions	48.55%
Alphabet, Jun 30	7.16%
Valor Management, Jun 30	6.54%

VALUATION & TREND · OCT 20 CLOSE

Trailing P/E (EPS −$1.10)	—
Forward P/E (EPS est. $2.16)	68.3
Price/sales (rev. $23.04B)	84.5
Beta	—
50-day average	$148.62 (−0.6%)
200-day average	—
Q4 EPS est. (2 analysts)	$0.36
Q4 revenue est. (12)	$21.33B

RECENT RATING ACTIONS

DATE	FIRM	RATING	TARGET
Oct 21	Cantor Fitzgerald	Overweight	$246 to $345
Oct 21	TD Cowen	Buy	$200 to $224
Oct 21	Needham	Buy	$250
Oct 20	Macquarie	Outperform	$250
Oct 16	Evercore ISI	Outperform	$230 to $275
Oct 9	Barclays	Overweight (initiated)	$254
Oct 7	Susquehanna	Neutral	$144 to $173

CATALYST CALENDAR

DATE	EVENT
Wed Oct 21	Starlink 15-15 retry; Tesla Q3 webcast 5:30 p.m. EDT
Thu Oct 22	**Lock-up release: up to 1.3B more shares**
Sat Oct 24	Lock-up tranche: up to 328.4M more
Thu Oct 29	FCC open meeting: direct-to-device spectrum votes
Wed Nov 4	FCC surety-bond deadline (15,000 satellites)
Mon Nov 30	FAA Starbase PEIS scoping comments due
Tue Dec 8	180-day lock-up ends

Prices and averages: Yahoo Finance via yfinance (unadjusted; 30-session average excludes Oct 20). Consensus, targets, ratings, short interest (Sep 30), ownership (Jun 30, % of Class A) and estimates: Yahoo Finance, retrieved Wed Oct 21, 8:44 a.m. EDT. P/E is price to earnings per share (EPS); price/sales uses trailing 12-month revenue. Dashes: not yet meaningful (negative EPS; listed Jun 12). Options: CBOE delayed quotes; open interest (OI) and IV as of Tuesday's close; P/C is put/call by OI; ATM IV at the $148 strike. Shares: 10-Q cover (7,696,293,669 Class A + 5,485,486,276 Class B, Jul 28); $2.01T adds 391,041,680 Cursor merger shares (8-K). IPO price and lock-ups: prospectus (424B4). FCC dates: Exterra, Broadband Breakfast.